

FOUNDATION #5: SOCIAL JUSTICE

A world dedicated to social justice is a place where everyone receives respect and equal access to jobs, education, and health care regardless of race, gender, ethnicity, sexual orientation, age, physical or mental abilities, or economic background.

CHALLENGES

Gender Inequality — Racism — Heterosexism — Inadequate Health Care — Prisons

Gender Inequality

Discrimination and violence against women are still deeply rooted in many cultures around the world. In their lifetime an estimated one in three women in the world will be subjected to violence in an intimate relationship and one in five women will be a victim of rape or attempted rape.¹³⁸ To make matters worse, this violence is often shrouded by a culture of silence. In Thailand and other countries, sexual slavery is common, with over 2 million girls aged 5 to 15 trapped in the sex trade every year.¹³⁹

Nations often systematically deny women education, economic opportunities, health care, birth control, and equal legal protections.¹⁴⁰ Worldwide, women are twice as likely to be illiterate, and they earn 25% less than men earn.¹⁴¹ Lack of voting rights and women in government positions perpetuate a male-oriented world where women have little power. Worldwide, women only occupy 16% of national legislative seats.¹⁴²

Unfortunately, women's reproductive health is a low priority worldwide. Every minute a woman unnecessarily dies of pregnancy-related causes—more than half a million each year. Poor reproductive health conditions are the leading causes of illness and death among women ages 15-44.¹⁴³ The International Women's Health Coalition reports that, "One in 13 women in sub-Saharan Africa and 1 in 35 in South Asia die unnecessarily from causes related to pregnancy, unsafe abortion, and childbirth."¹⁴⁴ Hundreds of millions of women still have inadequate access to birth control, leading to 80 million unwanted pregnancies each year and 20 million unsafe abortions, which in turn result in an estimated 78,000 deaths annually.¹⁴⁵

While most of the US abortion debate is focused on the federal level with *Roe v. Wade*, many of the battles to maintain reproductive freedom for women are being lost at the state level. Currently, 87 percent of US counties have no abortion provider.¹⁴⁶ While South Dakota voters recently overturned their legislature's ban on abortion, many other states are attempting to pass similar legislation.

Despite making tremendous strides, US women still experience numerous injustices. Only 14 out of 100 US senators are women (and that is the highest number ever), while only 66 women are among the 435 members of the US House of Representatives — ranking 66th in the world in gender equality.¹⁴⁷

Sexual harassment, domestic violence, and sexual violence are still pervasive, with 900,000 reports to police of women assaulted by their male partners in 1998 alone. Single women head 55% of all families living in poverty.¹⁴⁸ And, although women have entered the workforce by the millions, they still perform considerably more housework and childcare than men do.

Racism

Racism is still having devastating effects in the US and around the world. Many racial and ethnic minorities are prevented from fully participating in their societies. Stereotyping and prejudice lead to exclusion and discrimination. The effects of racism vary from genocide and hate-crimes to segregation and fear. Recent events highlight the continuing significance of race and ethnicity in human relations. Tensions between Sunni and Shia muslims in Iraq have led to waves of violence. Riots in Paris uncover a segregated, disenfranchised immigrant population without economic opportunities. Hurricane Katrina hit the gulf coast of the US and revealed an African-American underclass that bear the full brunt of the disaster. Ultra-nationalist political parties gain strength in Europe, blaming economic and social problems on recent immigrants from Africa and the Middle East. A lack of political representation and economic resources perpetuates the marginalization of minorities.

Despite many decades of struggle, prejudice and discrimination live on in our racially segregated schools, neighborhoods, churches and workplaces. The staggering wealth inequality throughout the world hits people of color especially hard, even in the US. Our society creates significant inequalities in income, education, home ownership, treatment by police, treatment by the courts, access to health care, corporate America and the halls of government. In 2004, African-Americans (24.7%) and Hispanics (21.9%) were over twice as likely to live in poverty as Whites (8.6%).¹⁴⁹ In 2002, the US median household wealth for African-Americans was \$6,000, for Hispanics it was \$7,900 and for Whites it was \$88,000—that's over 11 times Hispanics and 14 times African-Americans.¹⁵⁰ Today, 33% of African-American and 29% of Hispanic children live below the poverty line in the US.¹⁵¹ These injustices are then perpetuated by an unequal educational system. Schools attended by predominantly African-American and Latino students tend to be poorly maintained, have more unqualified teachers, and few up-to-date textbooks.¹⁵²

People of color around the globe disproportionately bear the brunt of our society's creation of toxic chemicals and pollution. This fact did not seem to phase D.F. Goldsmith when they wanted to ship 118 metric tons of mercury (one of the largest stockpiles of toxic metals in the US) to India.¹⁵³ Mexican authorities estimate that less than one-third of the toxic waste created by American companies in Mexico is returned to the United States as mandated by

Mexican law.¹⁵⁴ The predominately black residents of “Cancer Alley,” a stretch of land along the Mississippi in Louisiana, are exposed to 4,517 pounds (2,049 kilograms) of chemical releases each year; the average American is exposed to 10 pounds (4.5 kilograms).¹⁵⁵ These cases are not unusual. Naturally, exposure to such toxins increases rates of illness and mortality.

Heterosexism

Homosexuals are perhaps the last group still culturally acceptable to slander. Around the world gays and lesbians are discriminated against and often forced to live in the shadows of their societies. Homosexual acts are even punishable by death in nine nations including Saudi Arabia and Pakistan.¹⁵⁶ Gay men attempting to marry in the United Arab Emirates face “government-ordered hormone treatments, five years in jail, and lashings.”¹⁵⁷

In the US, heterosexuals continue to benefit from many privileges that lesbians and gays do not have. Heterosexuals can legally marry, show affection in public, be with their partner during severe illness and receive tax benefits — while not needing to worry about hate crimes, discrimination, slurs or violence. Reflecting the intense heterosexism still prevalent around the nation, by 2006, 26 states had passed constitutional amendments restricting marriage to heterosexual couples, and 12 more are currently considering such legislation.¹⁵⁸ Kids continue to torment young lesbians and gays at school, reflecting our society’s deeply rooted homophobia.

Inadequate Health Care

Billions of poor people have inadequate access to basic health care. The World Health Organization states, “The poor are treated with less respect, given less choice of service providers, and offered lower-quality amenities. In trying to buy health care from their own pockets, they pay and become poorer.”¹⁵⁹ Infant mortality in sub-Saharan Africa is 36 times higher than in Sweden.¹⁶⁰ Due mostly to the AIDS epidemic, the average life expectancy in Zambia has fallen from 54 in 1991 to 32.¹⁶¹ For the same reason, Zimbabwe’s life expectancy fell from 65 to 33.¹⁶² There are enough resources and pharmaceuticals to significantly reduce the AIDS crisis, but the people who need them the most, the poor, can’t afford them.

Despite being the richest country in the world, the US is the ONLY industrialized country that does not have universal health insurance—16% of Americans (46 million people) have no health insurance.¹⁶³ In fact, the World Health Organization ranked the United States health care system 37th in the world because it is enormously expensive and excludes tens of millions of people from quality care.¹⁶⁴

Prisons

While prisons are necessary to protect the general population from dangerous criminals, authorities often misuse prisons to control their populations. In non-

democratic nations, prisons are often used to silence political opponents and to send a message that dissent is not allowed. Family members disappear in the middle of the night, never to be seen again.

The US is quickly becoming the prison capital of the world, incarcerating a higher percentage of its citizens than any other country. In 2000, over 2 million people called US prisons and jails “home”—the majority for non-violent drug offenses.¹⁶⁵ An astounding increase in imprisonment took place during the 1990s. We had fewer than 200,000 adults behind bars in 1970; 315,974 in 1980; and 739,980 in 1990.¹⁶⁶

Despite widely acknowledged statistics showing that the national crime rate (including violent crime) has been going down for years, politicians continue to be rewarded for appearing “tough on crime.”¹⁶⁷ Since few dollars end up focused on reintegration and rehabilitation, the prison system has become merely a place to lock up our societal problems and hope they go away.

GOALS

Equal Rights For All — Universal Health Care and Education

Equal Rights For All

We need to ensure that no one faces discrimination due to their personal characteristics or background. People of color and ethnic minorities deserve non-stereotypical cultural images, equal access to education and jobs, fair political representation, and just treatment in the legal system. The Association of Community Organizations for Reform Now (ACORN) has empowered communities of color by registering over 1 million new voters in the 2004 election alone. They have also organized successful living wage campaigns in Chicago, Boston, Oakland, Detroit, Minneapolis, and St. Paul, forced companies to clean up toxic dumps, and successfully pressured banks to reinvest in their communities.¹⁶⁸

Women worldwide should be guaranteed equal pay for equal work, as well as proportional representation in their respective governments and strengthened legislation protecting them from sexual assault. The United Nations’ Gender Development Index indicates that gender equality has improved in almost all countries over the past three decades.¹⁶⁹ These gains are directly tied to the growth of the global women’s movement. In protests to gain the right to vote and hold elective office, scores of Kuwaiti women have marched into local election offices and registered to vote, arguing that the voting ban violates their constitution’s gender non-discrimination clause.¹⁷⁰ In 1980, US women employed full-time only earned 60 cents for every dollar their male counterparts earned. By 2004, that number had risen to 77 cents.¹⁷¹ V-day, a movement to end violence against women, has spread to 81 countries and raised over \$30 millions dollars for local organizations.¹⁷²

Over the last two decades, the global movement for gay and lesbian equality has achieved great successes. In 1994, South Africa became the first country to

protect gay and lesbian equality in its constitution. In 2001, the Netherlands became the first country to grant gay and lesbian marriage equality, and Belgium, Spain, Canada and South Africa soon followed. More than fifteen other countries offer some form of legal recognition and rights for same-sex couples.¹⁷³ In addition, the US Supreme Court ruled as unconstitutional the remaining state laws that criminalized sexual relations for gays and lesbians. In 2004, fifteen US states that include almost 1/2 of the US population, had laws banning discrimination on the basis of sexual orientation.¹⁷⁴ Until lesbians and gays have equal rights and protections as individuals, couples, and parents, our society is not truly free. As a global society, we now have the opportunity to stand up and support equal rights and to nurture all loving relationships.

Universal Health Care and Education

The world community needs to commit itself to providing quality education for all of the human family. Studies in the developing world have found that the simple act of providing a free lunch to students leads to huge gains in attendance, educational performance, and how long students stay in school.¹⁷⁵ Increased education has a number of positive societal benefits — especially for women. Education leads to improved economic prospects, better reproductive health, smaller family size, and improved HIV awareness.¹⁷⁶

Significant gains in human well-being could be easily made with targeted investments in human health. Providing full access to family planning services could prevent millions of unplanned pregnancies, reduce the incidence of abortion, and cut maternal deaths by 20 to 35 percent!¹⁷⁷ In the late 1990s, Bangladesh committed to improving the health of women, children, and the poor. Between 1998 and 2002, maternal and child mortality decreased by over 20%.¹⁷⁸ In addition, the World Health Organization led a international coalition to eradicate polio from the globe!¹⁷⁹ The global number of polio cases decreased from 350,000 per year in 1988 to only 800 in 2003!

The world has more than enough resources to provide universal health care and education to everyone. Experts estimate that primary education for all children, the eradication of adult illiteracy, school lunch programs for the 44 poorest countries, assistance to preschool children and pregnant women in the 44 poorest countries, and universal basic health care and family planning would cost the world community an additional \$68 billion in international aid.¹⁸⁰ That may seem like an overwhelming amount of money. But that figure, equivalent to roughly 15% of the annual Pentagon budget, totals less than one-fifth of one percent of the world's income.¹⁸¹ Americans spent more on cosmetics (\$8 billion) in 1998 than it would have cost (\$6 billion) to provide basic education for all people in the world who did not have it.¹⁸² Extending access to basic health care and nutrition to those without would cost \$13 billion annually — that's \$4 billion less than US and European pet owners spend on pet food.¹⁸³

➡ RESOURCES

- 📖 Cole, Luke, and Sheila Foster. *From the Ground Up: Environmental Racism and the Rise of the Environmental Justice Movement*. New York University Press, 2000. A fascinating history of the environmental justice movement and the factors that lead toxic facilities to be placed in poor communities of color in the United States. Their work documents how thousands of people are now fighting for their children, their health, and their communities.
- 📖 Hallinan, Joseph T. *Going Up the River: Travels in a Prison Nation*. Random House, 2003. Portrays the causes and effects of the “prison boom” that has incarcerated two million people in the US. Tells the stories of wardens, inmates, guards, prison planners, townspeople, and others.
- 📖 Kivel, Paul. *Uprooting Racism: How White People Can Work for Racial Justice*. New Society Publishers, 2002. Provides an understanding of white privilege and racism and offers concrete suggestions on how to resist oppression.
- 📖 Kozol, Jonathan. *Amazing Grace: Lives of Children and the Conscience of a Nation*. HarperPerennial Library, 1996. Kozol describes the impacts of poverty and community breakdown in New York City’s South Bronx. Drugs, inadequate housing, rampant unemployment and overcrowded schools make a clarion call for justice for those living on the margins of our society. Also check out: *Savage Inequalities: Children in America’s Schools* (HarperPerennial Library, 1992), and *Ordinary Resurrections: Children in the Years of Hope* (HarperPerennial, 2001), also by Kozol.
- 📖 Marcus, Eric. *Is It a Choice?: Answers to 300 of the Most Frequently Asked Questions About Gay and Lesbian People*. Harper San Francisco, 1999. Answers the questions about homosexuality that most people feel they can’t ask. A very readable, helpful book that leaves no topic untouched.
- 📖 Zinn, Howard. *A People’s History of the United States: 1492 to the Present*. HarperCollins, 1999. This classic presents history from the people’s point of view — those who have been made invisible in our national mythology — the oppressed, the enslaved, the impoverished. A gripping historical overview that you won’t find in conventional history books.